Q+A

A Poet *Among* Politicians

For **Pankaj Tripathi**, it was all about nailing the inner persona of Atal Bihari Vajpayee in *Main Atal Hoon*

Q. Political biopics have been hard sells in India. Are you hopeful that *Main Atal Hoon* will change that?

There's a thin line between a political film and a biopic of a politician. There's, of course, politics in *Main Atal Hoon*, but he's also a multidimensional personality; so, there are his thoughts, his journey, the challenges he faces and a focus on his literary side and personal life. There will be things that you didn't know of.

Q. How did you go about embodying a personality who was well known for his oratory and mannerisms?

I didn't want to mimic him. Yes, there were two hours of prosthetics involved and an effort made to catch some speech patterns, but it was more important to nail the internal...his persona, his consciousness, how he thinks and understand his *sur* [voice]. And what his state of mind was when he said or did something instrumental.

Q. What can today's politicians learn and imbibe from Atal Bihari Vajpayee?

Atalji was a deadly combination of poet and politician. I feel 15-20 of his speeches and poems must be mandatory reading for anyone who wants to join politics. They should learn parliamentary behaviour, democratic values and etiquette from him. He has famously said that '*Humse bolne ki kala mat seekho, humse chup rehne ki kala seekho* [Don't learn the art of narration but the art of silence from me]'.

Q. Which side of him did you connect with most?

I connected with all his aspects. Be it poet, politician, statesman or as an individual–his approach to life, society, all of it was inspiring. He had an aesthetic sense towards life. What resonated a lot was his opinion that it's not possible that everybody will like you. The bigger you get in stature, the bigger should be your power to tolerate.

–with Suhani Singh